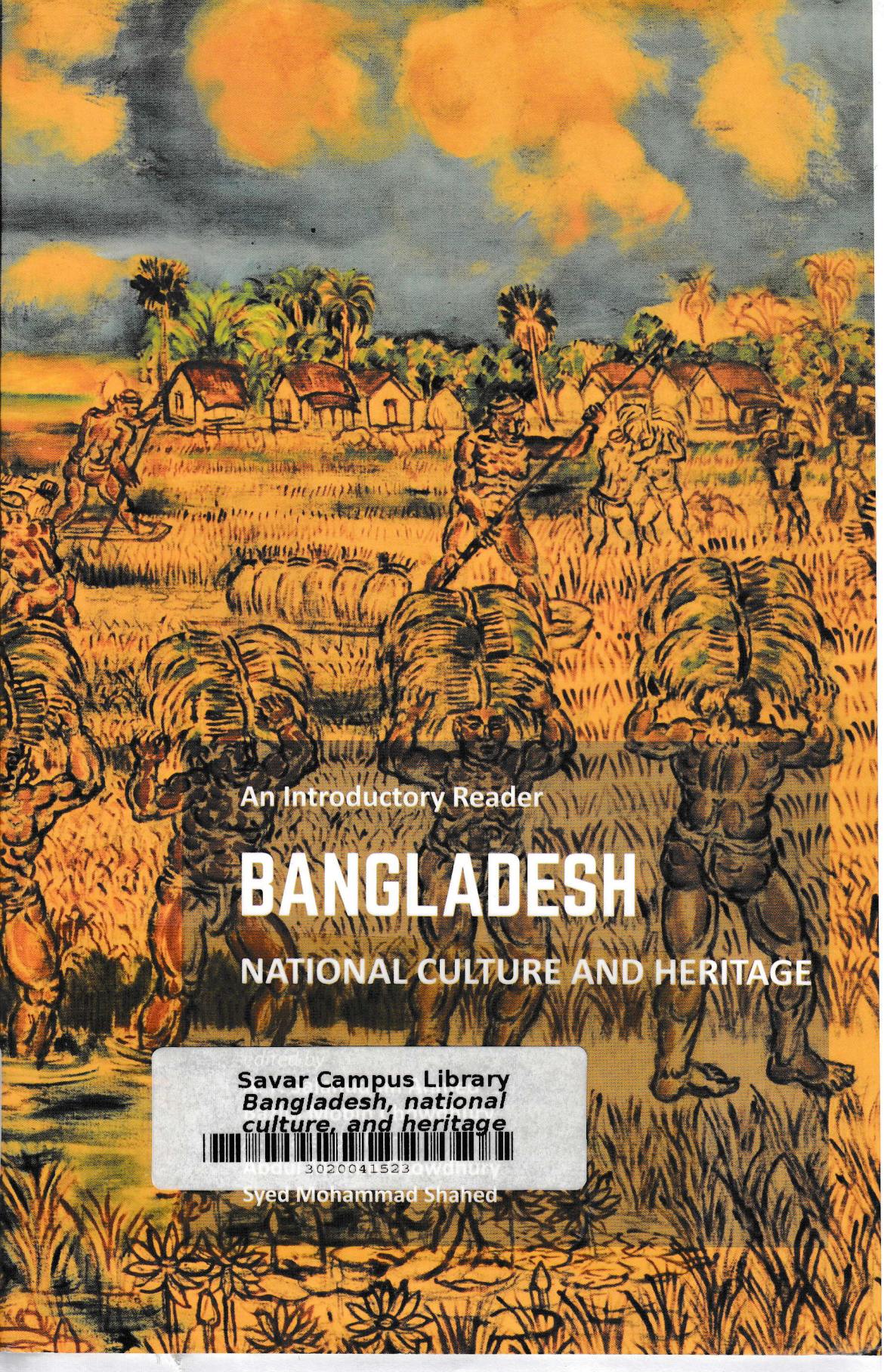


An Introductory Reader

BANGLADESH

NATIONAL CULTURE AND HERITAGE

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Syed Mohammad Shahed

An Introductory Reader

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NATIONAL CULTURE AND HERITAGE

edited by
A. F. Salahuddin Ahmed
Bazlul Mobin Chowdhury
A. Majeed Khan
Abdul Momin Chowdhury
Syed Mohammad Shahed

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Chapter 2

ANCIENT BANGLADESH

Political History

Abdul Momin Chowdhury

The reconstruction of the history of Bengal in the pre-Muslim period is difficult due to a paucity of sources. This difficulty is even more acute for the period before the 4th century CE, when Bengal came under the rule of the Gupta Empire. From then onwards, there are written records in the form of epigraphs and literature that contain information on the history of Bengal. For the earlier period, we have to depend on scanty references to the region in the Vedic, Epic, and Puranic literature, as well as on the available archaeological evidence.

It must be made clear at the very outset that by "the region of Bengal" I mean the territories of present-day Bangladesh and the state of West Bengal in India. It must be realized that the history of the region in the ancient period was not separated according to present-day boundaries. Therefore, for the ancient period, it is imperative to consider the history of the region of Bengal as a whole.

Background

In the earliest period, Bengal was known to be inhabited by several groups of people whose names then came to be associated with the area they inhabited. Thus the ancient *janapadas* of Vanga, Pundra, Radha, and Gauda were inhabited by non-Aryan ethnic groups bearing those names. Pundra roughly comprised the territories of northern Bangladesh and parts of northern West Bengal, whereas Gauda denoted parts of central West Bengal. Radha included the southern part of present West Bengal. Vanga denoted the major portion of present Bangladesh: its southern and southeastern districts. Samatata was an important *janapada* in the trans-Meghna region of southeastern Bangladesh (the Comilla-Noakhali area). The name of this *janapada* was purely descriptive and had no connection to ethnicity. The Chittagong region and its adjacent areas were known by the name of Harikela. The existence of these *janapadas*

is known from the later Vedic literature as areas inhabited by non-Aryan people.

Aryan influence came to be felt in the northwestern parts of ancient India in the middle of the second millennium BCE, but it took a long time for the Aryans to reach the eastern limits of the subcontinent. Thus the people of Bengal felt the tide of Aryanization quite late. From about the 5th century BCE, Aryans pushed into Bengal from the west, after which it took about one thousand years to Aryanize the whole of Bengal. By the time Aryan influence reached Bengal, it had become feeble from its long march through northern India. Thus the pre-Aryan elements in the culture of the people of Bengal were rooted deeply; even under Aryan influence, they retained many elements in their life and culture that were non-Aryan and even definitely pre-Aryan.

Stone tools provide the earliest evidence of human settlements in Bengal. Pre-historic stone implements have been discovered in various parts of West Bengal in the districts of Midnapur, Bankura, and Burdwan. But it is difficult to determine, even approximately, the time when the people using them first settled in Bengal. It might have taken place 10,000 years (or even more) ago. The original settlers were the non-Aryan ethnic groups—Nishadas or Austric or Austro-Asiatics—who are now represented by the primitive peoples known as Kola, Bhil, Santal, Sahara, Pulinda, etc. At a subsequent age, peoples of two other ethnic stocks whose language was Dravidian and Tibeto-Burman settled in Bengal.

The archaeological discoveries made during the 1960s have furnished evidence of a comparatively high degree of civilization in certain parts of Bengal, even as early as the beginning of the first millennium BCE—and perhaps even earlier. Discoveries at Pandu Rajar Dhibi in the valley of the Ajay river (near Bolpur) in Burdwan district of West Bengal and in several other sites on the Ajay, Kunar, and Kopai Rivers have thrown a fresh light on Bengal's pre-history. Pandu Rajar Dhibi is the ruin of a trading township, which carried on trade not only with the interior regions of India but also the countries of the Mediterranean world.

It is evident from the Vedic literature that the Aryans regarded the peoples they met in Bengal as barbarians. But evidence of the higher material culture that has come to light in West Bengal proves beyond any doubt the invalidity of the Aryan idea. At the same time, it must be said that the gradual establishment of Aryan settlements in Bengal profoundly affected its culture, and that the process of gradual Aryanization forms the prime point of interest in the subsequent history of the region. The

history of ancient Bengal from the 4th century CE onward, which is more or less clear to us from the written records, is the history of political and cultural Aryan domination.

Greek and Latin sources from the 3rd century BCE to 1st century CE refer to a state in eastern India called "Gangaridae" in Greek and "Gangaridai" in Latin. According to these sources, this state was very strong militarily. Scholars have located "Gangaridai" in parts of southern and southeastern Bengal, adjacent to the mouths of the Ganges (i.e., the Bhagirathi and Padma).[1]

An inscription written in the Brahmi script found during excavations at the site of the city of Pundranagara—now known as the ruins at Mahasthangarh in Bogra district—bears testimony to Maurya rule in parts of Bengal in the 3rd century BCE. This inscription, the earliest epigraphic record found in Bangladesh, establishes the site of ancient Pundranagara. Pundranagara is thus the earliest known urban settlement in Bangladesh. Archaeological excavations have indicated the continuing existence of this urban administrative and cultural center throughout the ancient period and up to the 12th century CE. The fragmentary Brahmi inscription refers to relief measures, such as the distribution of paddy and money, that should be undertaken by the administration during natural disasters and the collection of the distributed paddy and money when good days return. This proves that famines and natural disasters are old companions of the people in this part of the world. The idea of later returning the relief materials indicates mutual respect between the administration and the administered.

The *Arthasastra* of Kautiliya from the 3rd century BCE refers to the importance of the fine cotton fabric of Vanga (southeastern Bengal) for trade throughout India. The Greek and Latin writers also mention it. Thus it may be emphasized that the tradition of weaving fine cotton cloth goes back to a very early period. It was this item from southeastern Bengal that earned worldwide fame in the 16th and 17th centuries CE as the "muslin" of Bengal, and specifically of Dhaka. It may also be mentioned here that the making of terracotta plaques is a very old artistic tradition in Bengal; they have even been discovered in the excavations at Pandu Rajar Dhibi.

The Gupta Rule

The history of Bengal from the fall of the Mauryas in the 2nd century BCE to the rise of the Guptas in the 4th century CE is obscure. The discovery

[1] Majumdar, 1971:30.

of beautiful terracotta figurines dating to the 2nd and 1st centuries BCE at Mahasthangarh, Tamralipti, and Chandraketugarh indicates that Bengal continued to flourish during the Sunga and Kushan periods. It appears from accounts in *The Periplus of the Erythrean Sea* and Ptolemy that in the first two centuries of the Christian Era the whole of deltaic Bengal was organized into a powerful kingdom with its capital at Gange, a great market town on the banks of the Ganges. During this time, we have evidence of widespread trade between Bengal and China as well as other countries. The *Milinda-Panha* mentions Vanga in a list of maritime countries where ships congregated for the purpose of trade.

It is likely that on the eve of Gupta expansion under Samudragupta in the 4th century CE Bengal remained divided into independent states. By about the middle of the 4th century CE, however, most independent states had came under Samudragupta's rule. Samatata (the trans-Meghna region comprising Comilla-Noakhali area) remained outside his empire, but was reduced to the status of a tributary state. Samudragupta's son and successor Chandragupta II consolidated his possessions in the east and waged wars against the Vangas. Gupta suzerainty over Samatata might have come at a later stage; by the end of the 6th century CE, this area appears to have been ruled by a king whose name ended in -gupta (Vainygupta). Several copperplate inscriptions of the 5th century Gupta emperors (Kumaragupta-Budhagupta) found in northern Bengal prove the existence of a well-established Gupta rule in that area. They also testify to the existence of a well-structured local administration in which representatives of the local people had the opportunity to play an important part. It is to the credit of the Gupta emperors that they established an administration in Bengal in which the participation of the local people was ensured. The structure of the local administration, as evidenced by the Gupta copperplates, is undoubtedly the earliest instance of local self-government in Bengal that we have records for, and the significance of this cannot be overestimated.

The period of the Gupta Empire is generally considered to be a golden age in Indian history. During this period, India was under a strong benevolent central government that brought peace, wealth, and prosperity for a considerable time. Bengal was an important province and enjoyed the benefits of being a part of an all-India empire, in which an efficient administration and political stability prevailed. This period is remarkable for its trade and commerce, in which Bengal had its due share. The Chinese visitor Fa-hien states that Tamralipti (modern Tamluk in Midnapur

district of West Bengal) was the great emporium of trade in eastern India. The discovery of large numbers of Gupta and imitation Gupta coins in Bengal indicate the economic wealth of the region under the Guptas.

This period is also remarkable for religious tolerance. The imperial Gupta monarchs embraced Brahmanism and styled themselves Paramabhagavatas or Paramadaivatas, but also patronized Buddhism and Jainism. The people of the period enjoyed an environment of religious tolerance and coexistence of religious beliefs. The artistic excellence of the Gupta age is well known, and has influenced the artistic tradition of Bengal. The Gupta School inspired the Bengal school of sculptural art.

Sasanka

The decline of the Gupta Empire, the invasions of the Hunas, and the sudden entry and exit of Yasodharman on the political stage of northern India were great shocks for eastern India. In the first half of the sixth century CE, south and east Bengal shook off the suzerainty of the Guptas and attained importance as an independent kingdom under local rulers—the kingdom of Vanga. Meanwhile, the Maukharis rose to prominence in the central part of northern India and the later Guptas held sway over Bihar and western and northern Bengal. There was a long, drawn-out struggle between the Maukharis and the later Guptas for the possession of Magadha (southern Bihar) and parts of western and northern Bengal.

Towards the close of the sixth century CE, the kingdom of Gauda emerged in parts of western and northern Bengal under the rule of the later Guptas. But by the beginning of the seventh century, Gauda emerged as an independent kingdom under Sasanka, with Magadha part of his dominions. There is no doubt that Sasanka occupies an important place in the history of Bengal. He is the first known king of Bengal to extend his control over territories far beyond the geographical boundaries of the province. He attempted to establish a North Indian empire and preserved the independence of the Gauda Empire against a very powerful adversary, Harshavardhana, who founded a vast empire embracing practically all of northern India and parts of southern India. It was no mean achievement on the part of Sasanka to have preserved his independence against such a powerful adversary. For a king of Bengal, it was a great show of strength to venture into North Indian politics.

We do not have any concrete evidence concerning the early life of Sasanka and how he came to occupy the throne of Gauda. But it seems clear that he ruled over a vast territory. He made himself the master of

western and northern Bengal and conquered territory as far as Chilka Lake in Orissa. Parts of Bihar (Magadha) were also within his empire. He ventured as far as Kanauj in the central part of northern India, taking advantage of the contemporary political situation and an alliance with Devagupta, the ruler of Malwa in western India. His capital, Karnasuvarna, has been identified with Rangamati, six miles southwest of Baharampur in Murshidabad district of West Bengal.

Sasanka was a staunch Shaivite (follower of Shiva); the Chinese Buddhist pilgrim Hsuen Tsang depicts him as strongly anti-Buddhist and ascribes many acts of vandalism and enmity against Buddhists to him. We do not know whether the accusations made by this contemporary Buddhist author who was a great friend of Sasanka's adversary Harshavardhana are correct. However, political reasons rather than religious enmity may have prompted the persecution of Buddhists in certain areas. Almost all of the information that is available to us about this great king of Gauda comes from hostile sources. If he had a biographer like Banabhatta or a foreigner friend like Hsuen Tsang, his character might have been portrayed as attractively as that of Harshavardhana. But it can hardly be disputed that he was the first important king of Bengal who launched Bengal's history of aggressive endeavors to establish supremacy over northern India. In this sense, he was the forerunner of the aggressive northern Indian policy of the later Pala rulers like Dharmapala and Devapala.

Matsyanyayam is the condition in Bengal following the death of Sasanka that was marked by anarchy and lawlessness. For more than a century, roughly from 650 to 750 CE, the history of Gauda is extremely obscure. In northern India, the period was marked by political chaos and confusion caused by the death of Harshavardhana in 646 or 647 CE, the usurpation of his kingdom by his ministers, and the adventures of the Chinese envoy Wang-biuen-tse. It was followed by the invasions of the powerful Tibetan king Srong-tsan-Gampo. In the second half of the seventh century CE, Bengal witnessed the emergence of two new lines of kings: the later Guptas in Gauda and Magadha (western Bengal and southern Bihar) and the Khadgas in Vanga and Samatata (southern and south-eastern Bengal). Neither of these dynasties, however, appears to have succeeded in establishing a united and strong rule in Bengal.

In the first half of the 8th century CE, Bengal was overwhelmed by repeated foreign invasions, the most notable being the invasion of Yasovarman of Kanauj (725-752 CE). The glories of Yasovarman were soon eclipsed by Lalitaditya of Kashmir. The Kashmiri historian Kalhana

refers to five Gauda kings who were defeated by Lalitaditya; this clearly indicates a state of political disintegration in Gauda, which became a field of struggle for local chiefs who took up independent rule in the absence of any central authority. The successive foreign invasions destroyed the political equilibrium and hastened the process of disintegration.

The condition of Bengal towards the middle of the 8th century CE, before the rise of Gopala, was mentioned in one of the Pala records (Khalimpur copperplate) as a state of *matsyanyayam*. Taranatha, the Tibetan monk who wrote a history of Buddhism in India in 1608 CE, confirms this and writes: "every Ksatriya, Grandee, Brahman and merchant was a king in his own house (or in the neighbourhood) but there was no king ruling over the country." Gopala, the founder of the Pala dynasty, emerged as the ruler out of this chaos, and, as mentioned in the Pala copperplate, put an end to the state of lawlessness (*matsyanyayam*).

The Sanskrit term *matsyanyayam* has special significance. Kautiliya's *Arthasastra* explains the term as follows: when the law of punishment is kept in abeyance, it gives rise to such disorder as implied in the proverb of fishes—i.e., the larger fish swallows a small one, for in the absence of a law-enforcing authority the strong will swallow the weak. The contemporary Pala record uses this term to describe the prevailing political situation in Bengal, a situation of complete lawlessness originating from the absence of a strong ruling power capable of enforcing law and order. Gopala emerged at the helm and succeeded in putting an end to this state of *matsyanyayam*.

The process of Gopala's rise to power has been a matter of controversy among historians. Some have argued that the people elected Gopala as their king and one has gone so far as to say,

> About the middle of the eighth century A.D. a heroic and laudable effort was made to remedy the miserable state of things. The people at last realised that all their troubles were due to the absence of a strong central authority and this could be set up only by voluntary surrender of powers to one popular leader by the numerous chiefs exercising sovereignty in different parts of the country. [...] It is not every age, it is not every nation, that can show such a noble example of subordinating private interests to public welfare.[2]

Without going into the details of the controversy, it may be said that Gopala came to occupy the throne at a time when there was chaos and confusion and he must have had the support of a group of influential people

[2] Majumdar, 1943:44.

or leaders; his success in putting an end to the state of *matsyanyayam* may also have earned him popular support. It is claimed in the Pala records that Gopala attained everlasting peace after having overcome the power of those who were acting according to their own desires—in other words, those who had created the situation of *matsyanyayam* in Bengal.[3]

The Pala Dynasty

The dynasty founded by Gopala in the mid-8th century CE ruled Bengal for about 400 years amid various vicissitudes. During this protracted period of 18 generations of kings, there were ups and downs in the fortunes of the dynasty. But there can hardly be any doubt that the rule of the Palas formed a glorious chapter in the history of ancient Bengal. The history of the long line of Pala rulers can be viewed as three different phases: (i) the *Period of Ascendancy* under Dharmapala (c. 781-821 CE) and Devapala (c. 821-861 CE); followed by a (ii) *Period of Stagnation* (c. 861-995 CE), from which it was rejuvenated by Mahipala I (c. 995-1043 CE), who is considered the second founder of the dynasty; and the last phase, the (iii) *Period of Decline and Disintegration*, which was halted briefly by the vigorous rule of Ramapala (c. l082-1124 CE). The Pala Empire did not last long after Rampala's death; its final collapse came with the rise of the Senas in the third quarter of the 12th century CE.

The Period of Ascendancy saw the vigorous rule of Dharmapala and Devapala. During this period, the Palas were powerful enough to challenge the mastery of northern India, and became involved in a tripartite struggle for power with the Rashtrakutas of southern India and the Gurjara Pratiharas of western India. As Bengal saw the rise of the Palas, the Rashtrakutas wrested power from the Chalukyas in the Deccan and the Gurjara Pratiharas consolidated their power in Malwa and Rajasthana. In northern India, there was a vacuum after the invasions by Yasovarman and Lalitaditya. During the subsequent two generations, the three new powers of the Palas, Rashtrakutas, and Gurjara Pratiharas rushed into northern India to fill this vacuum.

Dharmapala's reign saw two phases of this tripartite struggle for power over northern India. Although he suffered reverses during the first phase of this struggle, he achieved some success in the interval between the first and the second phase, when he succeeded in advancing his influence up to the traditional North Indian capital of Kanauj, where he placed

[3] Chowdhury, 1967:8-12.

his *protégé* Chakrayudha on the throne. At this time, the Pala Empire extended beyond the boundaries of Bengal and Bihar and as far as Kanauj. Dharmapala may have pushed his empire in other directions as well, one cannot be certain about the magnitude of success. In the second phase of the tripartite struggle, Dharmapala once again tasted reverses. But there is little doubt that he succeeded in maintaining his hold outside Bengal and Bihar. Dharmapala's name stands out in the annals of the Pala dynasty as a great conqueror, under whose leadership Bengal's influence came to be felt in northern India for quite some time.

Dharmapala was a devout Buddhist and a great patron of Buddhism. He is credited with the foundation of the Vikramasila monastery at Patharghata (6 miles north of Colgong and 24 miles east of Bhagalpur in Bihar), which was one of the most important seats of Buddhist learning in India from the 9th to 12th centuries CE. He also founded the Somapura Mahavihara at Paharpur (in Naogaon district of Bangladesh), the largest Buddhist monastery in the Indian subcontinent (about 1000 feet square), and the second largest in the world. Its square floor plan with an open space in the middle, the center of which is occupied by a cruciform central shrine built in gradually receding tiers, set the architectural pattern for monastic construction in the southeast Asian countries, especially Myanmar and Indonesia. The terracotta plaques decorating the wall surfaces at Paharpur are of exquisite quality, and portray scenes from the every day life of the people of Bengal in addition to religious subjects. The Paharpur examples stand out as the finest specimen of this age-old art of Bengal.

Devapala, the son and successor of Dharmapala, maintained his father's aggressive policies, and during his reign the struggle for supremacy over northern India continued. He may have had some initial success, but ultimately the Gurjara Pratiharas succeeded in establishing their empire over Kanauj and the adjacent territories. The Pala Empire extended in other directions, however, towards the southwest into Orissa and towards the northeast into Kamarupa.

The reigns of Dharmapala and Devapala formed the period of Pala ascendancy. These two rulers consolidated their empire in Bihar and northern and western Bengal. Under them, Bengal emerged as a powerful force in North Indian politics for the first time in its history. Bengal could hold its own against powerful rivals, because of their conquests, with these two rulers ended the period of glory.

The Period of Stagnation continued for more than 100 years and the reigns of five generations of kings. In this period the energy and vigor

manifest during the reigns of Dharmapala and Devapala were totally absent. There were hardly any attempts at expansion of the empire; instead, the Pala kings were not powerful enough to check incursions from the outside or uprisings from inside. The Kambojas rose to independence in parts of western and northern Bengal, and for a time the Pala Empire was confined to parts of Bihar.

The reign Mahipala I (c. 995-1043 CE) brought back some vitality and gave a second lease on life to the Pala Empire. He succeeded in regaining the lost territories in northern and western Bengal and returned the position of his dynasty to a firmer footing. But during the reigns of his successors, the fortune of the dynasty seems to have fallen to its lowest ebb. Repeated invasions of the North Indian powers (Kalachuris and Chandellas) suggest the weakness of the Pala Kings. Their weakness was fully exposed during the reign of Mahipala II (c. 1075-1080 CE), when the revolt of the Samanthas succeeded in northern Bengal under the independence rule of Divya, the Kaivarta chief. When the central authority becomes weak, it is natural that the forces of disintegration should play their part. The success of Divya is the most glaring example of this trend.

The vigor and energy of Ramapala (c. 1082-1124 CE) was the last significant flicker in the life of the Pala dynasty. He succeeded in restoring Pala authority in northern Bengal and in demonstrating his vigor through expansion programs. But his success was short-lived, and his successors were too weak to check the gradual decline. Vijayasena, possibly a feudal ruler in the Pala Empire, found the opportunity to gather strength ousted the Palas from their possessions in Bengal by the middle of the 12th century CE. Bengal then saw the emergence of a new power, the Senas, under the leadership of Vijayasena, whose ancestors hailed from Karnata in southern India.

The long rule of the Pala dynasty, spreading over about four centuries, gave Bengal the blessings of a stable government, which bore rich fruits in the arts of peace. The Palas were able to establish a sound administrative structure that was based on agrarian activities. Trade and commerce were not important factors in the Pala economy. Trading activities were possibly confined to within the region or at best just beyond the borders to the adjacent territories. The decline of the port of Tamralipti after the 8th century CE deprived the Palas of an outlet to a share of the sea-borne trade of Bengal.

The long Buddhist rule of the Palas generated an environment of religious tolerance in Bengal and the atmosphere of Hindu-Buddhist

amity and co-existence is noticeable. Their liberal patronage of Hindu gods and goddesses as well as of the Brahmins, who were employed in high state posts, clearly speaks to the sagacious policy of the rulers. This also resulted in narrowing the gap between the two religions—a process that culminated in the evolution of Tantric cults and practices among the Buddhists in Bengal. The socio-religious climate of the Pala period bred a spirit of tolerance and mutual co-existence, and this spirit had a far-reaching impact on the history of the land.

The Pala period is also significant for its achievements in the fields of arts. Buddhist Vihara architecture attained maturity in the Somapura Mahavihara at Paharpur, subsequently influencing structures in Southeast Asian countries. The terracotta art of Bengal also reached a high-water mark during this period. The Pala School of sculptural art later came to be recognized as a distinct phase in Eastern Indian Art. The artistic genius of Bengal's sculptors found full expression in the Pala period. Although literary works of the period have not survived in large numbers, the *Ramacharitam*, a great poetic work by the North Bengali poet Sandhyakaranandi, is testimony to the quality of composition in a rare type of verse where each line has two meanings. The anthologies of poetry compiled in the subsequent period contain many verses composed by poets from the 10th and 11th centuries CE. A few illustrated palm-leaf manuscripts of Buddhist texts also demonstrate excellence in the art of painting. Considering all of these achievements, the Pala period can rightly be considered the most glorious era in the early history of Bengal.

Dynasties of Southeastern Bengal

Southeastern Bengal seems to have preserved its independence as a political entity for quite some time during the ancient period. From the break-up of the Gupta Empire to the emergence of the Senas, the deltaic part of Bengal was never assimilated into the political system of northern and western Bengal, though there were occasional attempts to do so.

As early as the first half of the sixth century CE, southeastern Bengal was an independent kingdom—the kingdom of Vanga. The names of three kings, Gopachandra, Dharmaditya, and Samacharadeva, are preserved in six copperplates. It cannot be ascertained whether Sasanka's empire embraced southeastern Bengal. When the later Guptas captured power in Gauda in western Bengal, southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the Khadga kings. We know about three generations of Khadga kings who ruled Samatata (the Comilla-Noakhali area) from their capital at

Karmanta-vasaka (identified with Badkamta near Comilla). Two semi-independent feudatory chiefs, Lokanatha and Sridharana Rata, are also known to have ruled parts of Samatata in the 7th century CE.

Southeastern Bengal emerged as a huge and mighty kingdom under the Deva dynasty in the 8th century CE. Their capital was at Devaparvata (a city in the Mainamati-Lalmai area, the exact location of which is not yet settled). Four generations of Deva rulers (Santideva, Viradeva, Anandadeva, and Bhavadeva) ruled Samatata; they were contemporaries of the early Pala kings, who held sway over Bihar and northern and western Bengal. The Devas were Buddhists, and under their patronage the Mainamati area rose into prominence as an important Buddhist cultural center. The remains unearthed through archaeological excavations at Mainamati prove the existence of a few Buddhist Viharas (Buddhist religious and educational establishments), namely Salban Vihara, Ananda Vihara, and Bhoja Vihara, all built by the Deva rulers near their capital city of Devaparvata. The cruciform plan of the central shrine seen in a mature form at Paharpur seems to have originated in the Mainamati area, where earlier and smaller manifestations have been found. The Mainamati remains also contain terracotta plaques of high artistic merit.

In the 9th century CE, southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the kingdom of Harikela, which may have covered the area from Chittagong to Comilla. The Chandras followed the Harikela rulers; from the beginning of the 10th century CE, five generations of Chandra rulers (Trailokychandra, Srichandra, Kalyanachandra, Ladahachandra, and Govindachandra) ruled for about 150 years (c. 900-1500 CE). Their empire incorporated the area that had previously been Vanga and Samatata, comprising all of southern and southeastern Bangladesh and as far northeast as the Sylhet area. Their capital was at Vikrampur in present Munshiganj district south of Dhaka.

The Chandras were powerful rulers and could match the power of their contemporaries the Palas of northern and western Bengal. Srichandra was the greatest ruler of the dynasty and under his vigorous rule the Chandra Empire witnessed widespread expansion into territories in Kamarupa (Assam).

Taking advantage of the Kaivarta rebellion in the Pala Empire, the Varman dynasty established an independent rule in southeastern Bengal in the last quarter of the 11th century CE. The Varmans were Hindus, and their capital was also at Vikramapur. Five generations of Varmans (Jatavarman, Harivarman, Samalavarman, and Bhojavarman) ruled for less than a century (c. 1080-1150 CE) before being toppled by the Senas.

The rulers of southeastern Bengal commanded the sea trade through the vast coastal area of the Chittagong-Comilla region. The profitability of this trade is attested by the discovery of large numbers of silver coins in various parts of their empire. The accounts of Arab merchants and navigators written between the 9th and 11th centuries CE contain evidence of a flourishing sea trade in the coastal area of south-eastern Bengal, especially through a port that the Arabs called "Samandar," which has been identified with the area near the present Chittagong port. Through this trade, the rulers of southeastern Bengal were able to earn the bullion necessary for issuing silver coins. We also have evidence of boat building industries in the records of the period. The picture of a flourishing sea-trade emerges very clearly, and the resulting economic affluence of the area is beyond any doubt.

The Sena Dynasty

Towards the end of the 12th century CE, Vijayasena founded the Sena Empire. Although his forefathers hailed from the Kanata country of the Deccan, Vijayasena initially emerged into the politics of Bengal as a feudal ruler in West Bengal during the rule of the Pala Emperor Ramayana. During the period of decline of the Palas after Ramayana's death, Vijayasena rose into prominence and gradually grabbed power. He defeated the Varmans in southeastern Bengal and then ousted the Palas from northern and western Bengal. He also attempted to expand his empire into northern Bihar and the adjacent territories. The Palas lingered for some time in southern Bihar until the Muslim occupation of the area in the beginning of the 13th century CE.

The Senas held sway over Bengal for more than a century (c. 1097-1223 CE), during which five generations of kings (Vijayasena, Ballal Sena, Lakshmana Sena, Visvarupa Sena, and Kesava Sena) ruled. The first three kings of the dynasty—Vijayasena (c. 1097-1160 CE), Ballal Sena (c. 1160-1178 CE), and Lakshmana Sena (c. 1178-1206 CE)—were important figures in the dynasty. However, the invasion of Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji put an end to Sena rule in parts of western and northern Bengal in 1204 CE; Lakshmana Sena had to fall back onto his possessions in southeastern Bengal, where his two sons ruled for some time after his death.

It should also be noted that by defeating the Varmans and the Palas, Vijayasena succeeded in bringing the whole of Bengal under one unified rule that continued until 1204 CE. Thus, in a sense, it can be said that it was only under the Senas that the whole of Bengal came under a

single rule. Southeastern Bengal's independence during the preceding four centuries must have had deep-rooted socio-cultural consequences in the history of Bengal. Vikramapura, the capital of the Chandras and Varmans, was chosen as the Senas' capital as well.

The Sena rulers were HIndus, and their rule is considered to be a period of revival of Hinduism in Bengal. Ballal Sena is known to have attempted the establishment of an orthodox Hindu social order with caste rigidity. This was an attempt to restore Hindu orthodoxy in a society that had long lived in a social milieu of religious tolerance and Hindu-Buddhist amity. The decline of Buddhism in Bengal may be ascribed to this change in social order. It is not unlikely that Buddhism received a rude shock from this revival of orthodox Hinduism by the Senas; it was not Islam which overcame Buddhism, but a more jealous rival of nearer origin and it is clear that "Buddhism had already been severely crippled before the Muslims reached Bengal."[4] This scenario of Hindu-Buddhist enmity in Bengal and the attempt to bring back Hindu orthodoxy during the Sena period may be said to have had a far-reaching impact on the history of Bengal. In fact, it may have indirectly helped the cause of Islam in the region.

The Sena period is significant from another point of view: the development of Sanskrit literature in Bengal. It was partly through the direct patronage of the Sena kings, and partly because of the environment created by them that literary activities in Sanskrit are distinctly visible in this period. By far Bengal's most important contribution to the poetic literature in Sanskrit is the *Geeta Govinda* of Jayadeva, who was one of the ornaments of the court of Laksmana Sena. Other luminaries of his court were the poets Dhoyi (author of *Pavanaduta*), Umapatidhara, Govardhana (author of *Aryasaptasati*), and Sarana; these five poets may be regarded as the five *ratnas* (jewels) of the court of Lakshmana Sena. One anthology (*Saduktikarnamrta*) compiled by Sridharadasa during this period stands out as a treasure trove of poetic works from both this and earlier periods. It contains 2370 poems composed by 485 poets between the 10th and 12th century CE. Bhavadeva Bhatta and Jimutavahana, two great *Dharmasastra* writers, belong to this period. Ballal Sena and Lakshmana Sena were royal authors of no mean merit. Halayudha's *Brahmanasarvasva* was also written in this period. Mention of other works and authors would only make this list longer. 12th century Bengal under the Senas witnessed an unprecedented flourishing of literary activities in Sanskrit.

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[4] Ling, 1976:323.

Another arena of the artistic achievements of the period was in the field of sculptural art. The Bengal school of sculptural art reached its high water mark in the Sena period and in this phase its regional character marked by individualistic traits became manifest.

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